

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 48

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: An ageing factory worker describes his final shift on the line before a robotic arm takes over his role.

1

The alarm went off at four, as it had done for twenty-three years, and for twenty-three years I had cursed it. This morning, for the first time, I let it ring a few seconds longer than usual. I sat on the edge of the bed and listened, the way a man listens to a song he is unlikely to hear again. Then I rose, splashed cold water on my face, and put on the same blue overalls I had worn the day before. The cloth at the elbows had gone soft with washing. The name stitched above the chest pocket — **Yusoff** — had begun to fade. I caught myself looking at it in the mirror and thinking that letters, like men, eventually wear away.

2

The factory floor at five in the morning has a smell I will, I suspect, miss more than anything else. It is part machine oil, part warm rubber, part the faintly bready scent of cardboard boxes that have sat all night under fluorescent lights. I clocked in, nodded to the security guard, and walked down the long aisle towards Bay 14, where the conveyor and I had spent the better part of my life. Above the bay, fixed to the steel beams, the new robotic arm hung in its cradle. It was painted a tidy, businesslike orange. It did not look at me, because it had no eyes, but I had the foolish feeling, as I passed beneath it, that it was waiting.

3

The work itself was, as it had always been, a sequence of small, exact movements. Lift the component from the tray. Inspect the seam. Wipe the housing with a cloth. Press, twist, click. Set the finished piece on the conveyor; reach for the next. I had performed this sequence, I once calculated, somewhere in the region of eleven million times. People who had never stood on a line liked to call such work mindless. They were wrong. There is a particular intelligence in the hands of a man who has done a task for two decades — a quiet, careful skill that no one writes about and few people see.

4

At nine, Pak Razali, the foreman, came down the aisle. He had hired me when I was nineteen, and his hair had been a stubborn black then; now it was the colour of pewter. He stopped a little distance from my station, as though approaching a man at prayer, and waited until I had finished the piece in my hand. Then he held out his own hand. We shook in silence. He did not say anything maudlin, for which I was grateful. He only said, “Twenty years, Yusoff,” and looked at the floor for a moment, and then walked on. I did not turn to watch him go. I had work to finish.

5

At the morning break, the younger men on the line gathered around to take a photograph with me. They were kind boys. They called me **abang**, elder brother, and they meant it. One of them, a slim youth named Iskandar, asked me whether I was bitter. I told him, truthfully, that I was not. Bitterness, I said, was a poor companion to take into retirement. He looked unconvinced. I did not try to convince him. There are some things a young man has to learn for himself, and the difference between sadness and bitterness is one of them.

6

The afternoon hours went by, as the afternoon hours always had, in a kind of attentive, almost meditative blur. Lift, inspect, wipe, press, twist, click. The conveyor hummed its old hum. The fluorescent lights buzzed their old buzz. The robotic arm in its cradle did not move yet, because the engineers were saving it for Monday, but I could feel its patient orange presence above me like a polite shadow. I bore it no grudge. A machine cannot help being what it is, any more than a man can help growing old.

7

At five, the line stopped. I wiped down my station for the last time, more carefully than I had ever wiped it down before. I folded my cloth. I took my mug from its hook. Then I walked to the locker room, where I tidied my locker as though I were preparing it for the next man — though there would not, of course, be a next man. I left a folded note on the top shelf, in case anyone should look. It said only: **Be good to the line. The line has been good to me.**

8

At the gate, I turned and looked back once. The factory windows glowed yellow in the dusk. Somewhere inside, the orange arm was waiting for Monday. I felt no rage and no self-pity, only a small, surprising peace, as though I had finished a long letter and at last laid down the pen. I walked home through the cooling streets. I did not look back again.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says he listened to the alarm “the way a man listens to a song he is unlikely to hear again.” Explain, in your own words, what this comparison tells us about how the narrator feels on this particular morning. [2]

2. The narrator writes that “letters, like men, eventually wear away.” What does this thought suggest about how he is viewing himself? [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. Give **two** details from Paragraph 2 that show the narrator has a strong sensory attachment to the factory. [2]

4. The robotic arm “did not look at me, because it had no eyes, but I had the foolish feeling... that it was waiting.”

- (a) Why does the narrator call this feeling **foolish**? [1]
(b) What does the word **waiting** suggest about his attitude towards the machine? [1]

From Paragraph 3

5. The narrator says that people who have never stood on a line “liked to call such work mindless.” Explain, in your own words, why the narrator believes this view is wrong. [2]

From Paragraph 4

6. The foreman “stopped a little distance from my station, as though approaching a man at prayer.” Explain how this comparison shows the foreman’s respect for the narrator. Support your answer with **two** details from Paragraph 4. [3]

From Paragraph 5

7. The narrator tells Iskandar that “bitterness... was a poor companion to take into retirement.” What does this reply reveal about the narrator’s character? [2]

From Paragraph 6

8. The robotic arm is described as “a polite shadow.” What is **unusual** about this description, and what does it suggest about the narrator’s feelings towards the machine? [2]

From Paragraph 7

9. Give **one** piece of evidence from Paragraph 7 that shows the narrator wished to preserve the dignity of his work even at the very end. [1]

From Paragraph 8

10. The narrator describes the peace he feels as “small” and “surprising.” Explain what each of these two words tells us about his emotional state at the gate. [2]

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article on the global politics of rare-earth metals and the difficulty of building a secure supply.

1

Few materials have travelled so quietly from the laboratory to the front page as the rare-earth metals. The seventeen elements that go by this awkward collective name — neodymium, dysprosium, terbium and their less familiar cousins — are scarcely “rare” in geological terms; the earth’s crust contains them in respectable abundance. What is rare, and what has lately become the source of considerable diplomatic anxiety, is the ability to extract these elements in economically useful concentrations and to refine them into the powders, magnets and alloys on which the modern economy increasingly depends.

2

The list of products that cannot, at present, be built without rare earths is sobering. The electric vehicle that a household buys to reduce its carbon footprint relies on neodymium magnets in its motors. The wind turbines that turn slowly above coastal hills use the same magnets, on a far larger scale, in their generators. Modern fighter aircraft, guided missiles and submarines use terbium and dysprosium in their precision actuators and sonar systems. Mobile phones, hospital scanners and the polishing compounds used to finish glass screens — all of these draw, somewhere in their bill of materials, on the same handful of elements.

3

The problem is that the supply of these elements is unusually concentrated. By the most widely cited estimates, a single country — China — accounts for around sixty per cent of global rare-earth mining and well over eighty per cent of the world’s refining capacity. This is not the result of an accident of geology, but of decades of patient industrial policy: subsidised processing plants, tolerated pollution, and a willingness, in the 1990s and 2000s, to sell at prices that drove competitors out of business. Western governments, having outsourced both the dirty work and the technical know-how, now find themselves dependent on a single supplier for materials they have come to regard as strategically essential.

4

The environmental cost of this concentration is rarely advertised. Rare-earth mining produces enormous quantities of waste rock, often laced with low-level radioactive thorium. Refining is worse: the elements are separated through a long sequence of acid baths and solvent stages, which generate toxic effluent that, if poorly managed, contaminates rivers and groundwater for decades. The town of Baotou, in northern China, sits beside a tailings lake roughly ten square kilometres in area; residents have long complained of crops that will not grow and livestock that fall ill. The clean technologies that rare earths make possible are, in this awkward sense, built upon a dirty foundation.

5

The strategic response, over the past decade, has been to diversify. New mines have been opened, or reopened, in Australia, the United States and, more recently, in countries as varied as Vietnam, Greenland and Tanzania. Some of these projects are genuinely promising; others have stalled, defeated by the same hard economics that closed them in the first place. A mine is, after all, only the beginning of the chain. The far more difficult step — the building of a refinery capable of separating seventeen chemically similar elements at industrial scale — requires capital, expertise and a regulatory tolerance that no Western country has been entirely willing to grant.

6

Recycling is the second strand of the response, and a more elegant one. A used electric motor contains, in concentrated form, exactly the magnets that mines spend fortunes to extract from rock. Pilot plants in Belgium, Japan and Singapore have begun to recover neodymium and dysprosium from end-of-life

motors, hard disks and lighting at recovery rates that, ten years ago, would have been thought impossible. The bottleneck is no longer technical but logistical: collecting and sorting the relevant waste in sufficient volume, and at sufficient purity, to feed an industrial-scale refiner. Until that bottleneck is broken, recycling will remain a small, virtuous corner of a very large problem.

7

What, then, does supply-chain security actually look like for the rare earths? It is not, as is sometimes imagined, the achievement of a single grand mine in a friendly jurisdiction. It is, rather, a portfolio: several modest mines on several continents; two or three refineries operated to high environmental standards; a serious recycling industry; long-term stockpiles for genuinely strategic uses; and, perhaps most importantly, the political patience to fund these things through the years in which the market price of rare earths happens to be low. Whether democratic governments, with their short electoral cycles, possess that patience remains very much an open question.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says that rare-earth metals “are scarcely ‘rare’ in geological terms.” Explain, in your own words, what is **actually** difficult about obtaining these metals, according to Paragraph 1. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. Give **two** different categories of product, mentioned in Paragraph 2, that depend on rare-earth metals. [2]

14. The writer calls the list of products that depend on rare earths “sobering.” What does the use of this word suggest about the writer’s attitude? [1]

From Paragraph 3

15. According to Paragraph 3, how did one country come to dominate the rare-earth industry? Answer in your own words, giving **two** points. [2]

16. The writer says that Western governments “outsourced both the dirty work and the technical know-how.” Explain what is **critical** about the writer’s tone in this phrase. [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. The writer says that clean technologies are “built upon a dirty foundation.” Explain, in your own words, what this contradiction means. [2]

From Paragraph 5

18. According to Paragraph 5, opening a new mine is “only the beginning of the chain.” What is the **more difficult step** the writer identifies, and why is it so hard to take? [2]

From Paragraph 6

19. The writer describes the bottleneck for recycling as “no longer technical but logistical.” Explain, in your own words, what this distinction means. [2]

From Paragraph 7

20. The writer ends the article by asking whether democratic governments “possess that patience.” What does this final question suggest about the writer’s view of the future of rare-earth supply? [1]

21. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the environmental and strategic problems caused by relying on rare-earth metals**, and **the steps now being taken to make their supply more secure**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 3 to 7** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

The reliance on rare-earth metals creates problems because ...

— END OF PAPER —